Mumbai to be with his ailing mother-in-law, was asked to come back immediately and hold a press conference.

The next day, Tewari followed instructions and lambasted Hazare, suggesting he was ‘corrupt from head to toe’. It was an ill-chosen remark but one that had been officially sanctioned by the party. In his 15 August Independence Day address, Dr Singh was equally combative and said that the power to make laws rested only with Parliament. The battle between Hazare and the government had reached the point of no return.

But on the night of that very Independence Day, the Congress did another U-turn. Rahul had just returned from abroad and was angry with the criticism of Anna. ‘Kindly issue a fresh statement and let us distance ourselves from what Tewari has said about Anna. We must respect him,’ Rahul told chief Congress spokesperson Janardhan Dwivedi. ‘I felt totally abandoned,’ Tewari told me later. He had become the fall guy.

The confusion didn’t end there. Next morning, as Anna was preparing to go to Rajghat to pay his respects at Mahatma Gandhi’s *samadhi* before proceeding to the fast venue, the Delhi police landed up at his residence in east Delhi’s Mayur Vihar area and arrested him.

I was on my morning walk when the story broke. Still in a T-shirt and track pants, I rushed, like so many other 24/7 journalists, to the television studio. Little did I know then that for the next thirteen days, the Anna Hazare story would consume the entire airtime of a nation, to the exclusion of all other news.

Who ordered the arrest of Hazare? While the finger of suspicion pointed at the home ministry, Chidambaram told me later that the original decision to ‘detain’ Anna was taken by the Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs in the presence of the prime minister and senior ministers. ‘We never wanted to arrest him. We only told the Delhi police to detain him because he wasn’t willing to accept our demand for a time-bound fast. It was the local magistrate who ordered his arrest,’ Chidambaram claimed. By the time the magistrate’s order was reversed (see also chapter 2), it was too late. Public opinion had turned firmly against the government.